embargo on selling to Iran. . . . The plan is set for Wednesday.

Dec. 9

Bud is back from London but not in the office yet. His meeting with the Iranians did not achieve its purpose which was to persuade them to free our hostages first and then we'd supply the weapons. Their top man said he believed if he took that proposal to the terrorists they would kill our people.

Dec. 10

Began the day with a meeting, the Dem and Republican Congressional leadership. Spent most of our time on the Gramm Rudman Hollings bill which later in the day I found had made its way out of the conference. Not as good as we would have wanted but still a bill I'll have to sign. Some of the time we talked tax reform. I've done a lot of telephoning all day and still don't know whether it will pass. Bud M back from England and his meeting with the Iranian "go between," [Iranian arms merchant Manucher Ghorbanifar] who turns out to be a devious character. Our plan regarding the hostages is a "no go."

On December 12, our nation got another reminder of the high price we were having to pay for the continuing strife in the Middle East and our efforts to resolve the Arab-Israeli conflict: Nearly 250 American soldiers returning home after six months of duty as members of the international police force posted in the Sinai under the Camp David accords were killed when their plane crashed after a refueling stop in Newfoundland.

Less than three weeks later—two days after Christmas—we got still another reminder: Palestinian terrorists callously sprayed automatic weapons into crowds of passengers at